

Presidential Order, Feb. 19, 1942
The Rescues of the Government
in the name of the President
MEMORANDUM FOR SECRETARY MORGENTHAU

One of the greatest crimes in history, the slaughter of the Jewish people in Europe, is continuing unabated.

This Government has for a long time maintained that ^{its} ~~the~~ policy of ~~this Government~~ is to work out programs to save those Jews of Europe who could be saved.

^{sent} I am convinced on the basis of the information which is available to me that those officials in our State Department, ^{which is} ~~who have~~ been charged with carrying out this policy, have been guilty not only of gross procrastination and wilful failure to act, but even of wilful attempts to prevent action from being taken to rescue Jews from Hitler.

^{statement} I fully recognize the graveness of this charge and I make it only after having most carefully weighed the shocking facts which have come to my attention during the last several months.

^{remedial steps of a} ^{as} Unless ~~action of the most~~ drastic nature is taken, and taken immediately, I hereby state for the record that no effective action will be taken by this Government to prevent the complete extermination of the Jews in German controlled Europe, and that this Government will have to share for all time responsibility for this extermination.

^{I am certain} There are only two courses of action which can possibly prevent utter failure. They are:

(1) Those officials in the State Department who are responsible for this Government's failure to act to date must be fired; or

(2) The whole problem of working out programs for the rescue of Jews must be completely divorced from the State Department and responsibility and full and complete powers to deal with the situation placed in the hands of a Committee, composed of strong men who in their hearts really want to do something. This Committee would represent fully the interests of this Government and be responsible directly to the President.